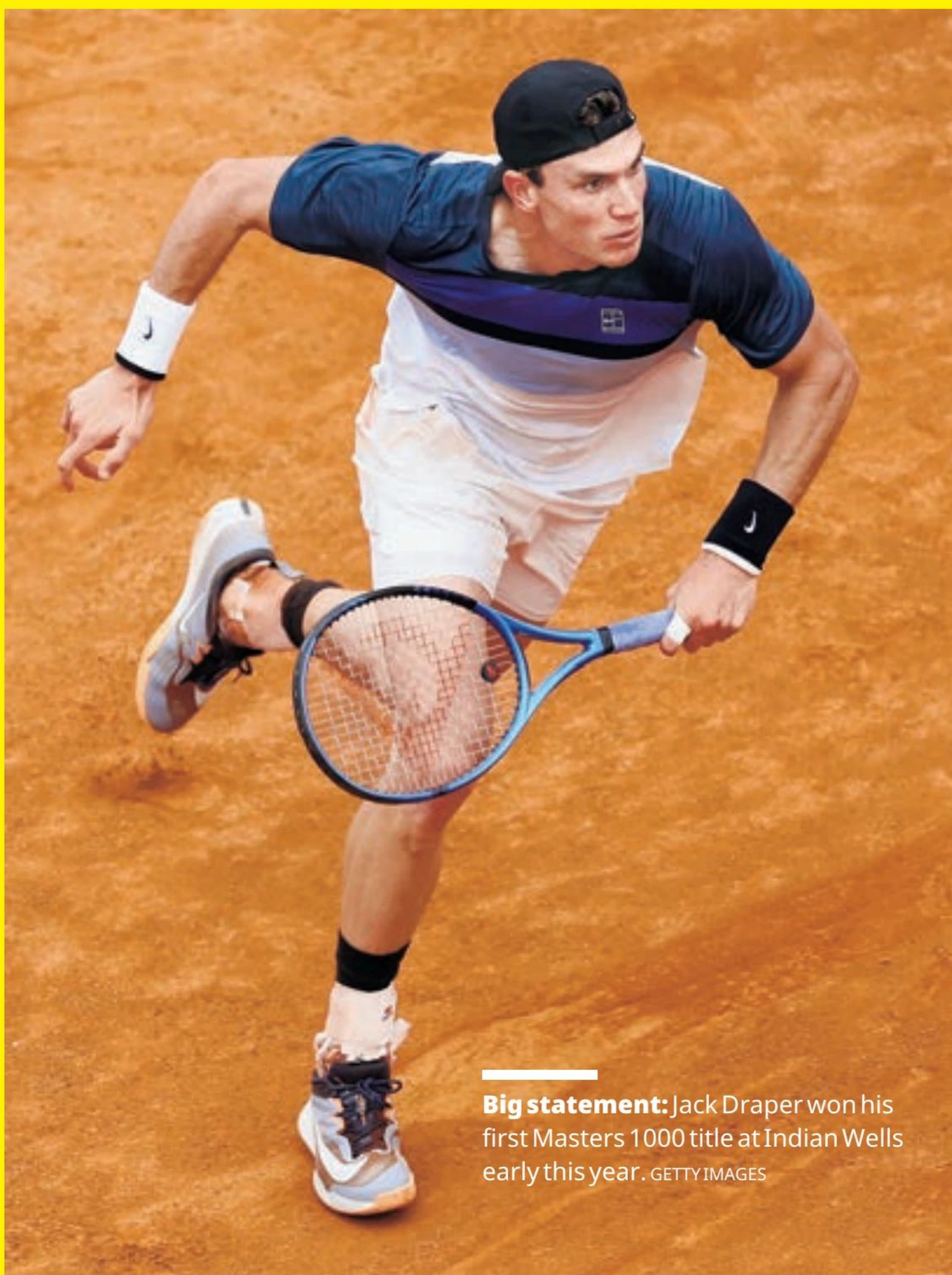




**Big statement:** Jack Draper won his first Masters 1000 title at Indian Wells early this year. GETTY IMAGES

Alcaraz in his right hand, and Sinner in his right forearm and left thigh. Alcaraz echoed the sentiments of Nadal, "You have to enjoy the suffering."

Like Sinner, he excels when it matters most. An exception was the Paris Olympics, where Djokovic edged him for the coveted gold. Still, Alcaraz has a stunning 10-1 record in Grand Slam and Masters 1000 finals. Crucially, he's beaten Sinner in their last three duels, all of them last year.

Sinner's absence from competition should make him the fresher of the two, in case they meet again. But Alcaraz must have his fervent fans worried after this revelation on his new *Netflix* documentary: "Right now, my biggest fear is ending up seeing

tennis as an obligation. Sometimes I feel enslaved to tennis — and that causes anxiety, frustration, doubts. I ask myself, do I really want this life, with that pressure, and to keep going?" I personally think his passion for competing and showing off his dazzling repertoire will offset his fears, and he'll add a second Eiffel Tower tattoo to his sculpted body.

#### **No. 5 Jack Draper**

"Pressure is a privilege," tennis legend Billie Jean King likes to say. But for Jack Draper — this season's breakout British player — pressure has become an exhausting burden barely five months into the year.

"When I get out of bed, I feel so angry some days. And, you know, I've got to play a tennis match and lose points, so I've got to go through

those emotional ups and downs," Draper told *Sky Sports'* Gigi Salmon. "I'm in a new position now. My ranking's going up, and I'm competing week in, week out, playing lots of matches. That's taken some getting used to — mentally and physically. I want to keep going, but yeah, it's sometimes difficult to always be perfect."

Even so, the 23-year-old British left-hander was runner-up at Doha, and upset Alcaraz and World No. 4 Taylor Fritz to win his first Masters 1000 at Indian Wells. The ruggedly built 6'4", 190-pound Draper also excels on clay. He made the Madrid final, overpowering Tommy Paul and Lorenzo Musetti before falling to the more experienced Casper Ruud in an exciting 7-5, 3-6, 6-4 contest.

"I think he has very few, if any, weaknesses," Ruud said. "He's big, strong, and moves well. He can defend brilliantly and also play aggressively.... You're scared of his forehand because he rips it cross-court and down the line. And you're scared of his backhand because he can rip and counter from that side too.... He's definitely got an incredible future on any surface."

Injury-prone Draper, who works with a breathing coach to manage stress, will be tested physically and mentally like never before in the long, gruelling matches at Roland Garros. With a favourable draw, a semifinal appearance is likely his ceiling this year.

#### **No. 7 Casper Ruud**

The greatest player in Norwegian tennis history has had the misfortune of facing two of the Big Three and a rising superstar in his three Grand Slam finals — Nadal, his boyhood idol, at the 2022 French Open, Djokovic at the 2023 French Open, and Alcaraz at the 2022 US Open. After achieving a career-high No. 2 ranking in September 2022, Ruud plunged to No. 15 in April this year. He endured a lacklustre season, failing to beat any top 15 opponent until his resounding resurgence in Madrid, where he defeated Fritz, Daniil Medvedev, Cerundolo, and Draper.

How does the mild-mannered